



Rumi Mirror

WORLD USABILITY DESIGN CHALLENGE 2026

Designing a Sustainable Future with Ethical AI

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A concise view of the evidence → decisions → outcome

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01

Introduction

The problem & core thesis



01 Introduction



Rumi is one of the most quoted poets in the English-speaking world, but a large share of what circulates under his name is not his.

CORE THESIS



AI can protect the accuracy and integrity of a cultural and literary heritage, instead of generating content freely at the risk of eroding it further.

As AI chatbots become a common way people encounter “Rumi quotes,” that drift is accelerating: language models confidently attribute verses to Rumi that don’t exist anywhere in his actual work.

02

User Research

People, behavior & trust



02 User Research

Research changed the explanation before the interface

4+ years

personal engagement
with Rumi's poetry

2 years

product design work
on Ganje Molana

CONCEPT TEST · BEFORE

“I’m not clear what the solution will be... why do you care?”



AFTER THE VALUE WAS MADE EXPLICIT

“This I get. This is crystal clear.”

– Vlad

What unlocked clarity: product form, personal motivation, and ethical-AI framing.

The first design problem was communication.

02 User Research

Small sample, clear signal: trust drives adoption

4 / 4

already search for Rumi
verses online

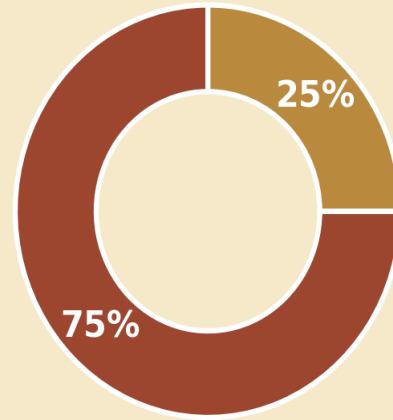
3 / 4

have doubted a quote's
authenticity

50 / 50

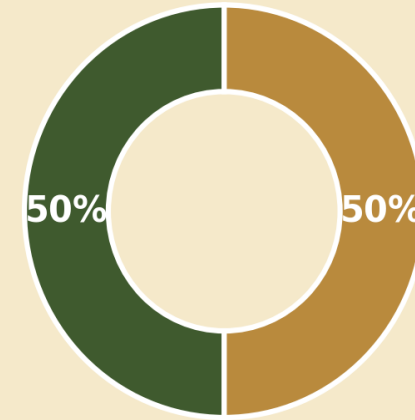
definitely / maybe would use
the app

**Have you doubted a Rumi
quote's authenticity online?**



■ Yes, a few times
■ No, never

**Would you use an app
like this?**



■ Yes, definitely
■ Maybe

“It would depend heavily on the website’s accuracy and reliability... If it provided fully accurate references, I would be happy to use it.”

Rumi study group · n = 4

02 User Research

Two personas reveal two different trust barriers



PERSONA 1

The Skeptical Outsider

Japanese • unfamiliar with Rumi

Needs to understand what the product is and why it matters within seconds.

✓ “This is crystal clear.”



PERSONA 2

The Devoted Reader

International • deeply familiar with Rumi

Needs accurate sourcing and interpretation before trusting the experience.

🛡️ Accuracy over polish

Shared need

Credibility must be visible, not merely claimed.

Fictional archetypes synthesized from research; portraits are illustrative.

03

Ideation

Testing the concept before code



03 Ideation

The concept became concrete before any code

 BEFORE

Free text

Emotion entered as arbitrary language, hard to interpret consistently and likely to feel like a generic chatbot.



 AFTER

Structured selection

A fixed emotional taxonomy gives people an understandable starting point and keeps matching behavior constrained.

Decision rule: reduce ambiguity before adding intelligence.

04

Designing

Product mechanics & decisions



04 Designing

The product: mood in, verified verse out

[← Back to categories](#)

Verify a Quote

Paste a quote attributed to Rumi. We'll check it against our verified source database.

Forasmuch as you are too dull to apprehend these wonders,
if you say "yea" you will be straying from the truth;

Check quote

✓ Confirmed

This quote matches a verified verse in our source database.

“*Forasmuch as you are too dull to apprehend these wonders, if you say “yea” you will be straying from the truth;”*

Rumi, Mathnavi, Book 4, Line 3749

N

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Design and development by [Delara Mozdbar](#) [Sources](#)

😊 01 Choose a feeling

A structured emotional category sets the search space.

🛡️ 02 Retrieve, never generate

The system returns a curated verse and exact source.

🔍 03 Reflect and verify

Plain-language reflection plus source confirmation.

30 curated verses · Books 1–4

04 Designing

Four guardrails turn ethical intent into product behavior

01 **Retrieval, not generation**

Never invent a verse, citation, or wording.

02 **Public-domain sourcing**

Use Nicholson's Books 1–4 translation.

03 **Human-authored reflection**

Interpretation is based on study and review.

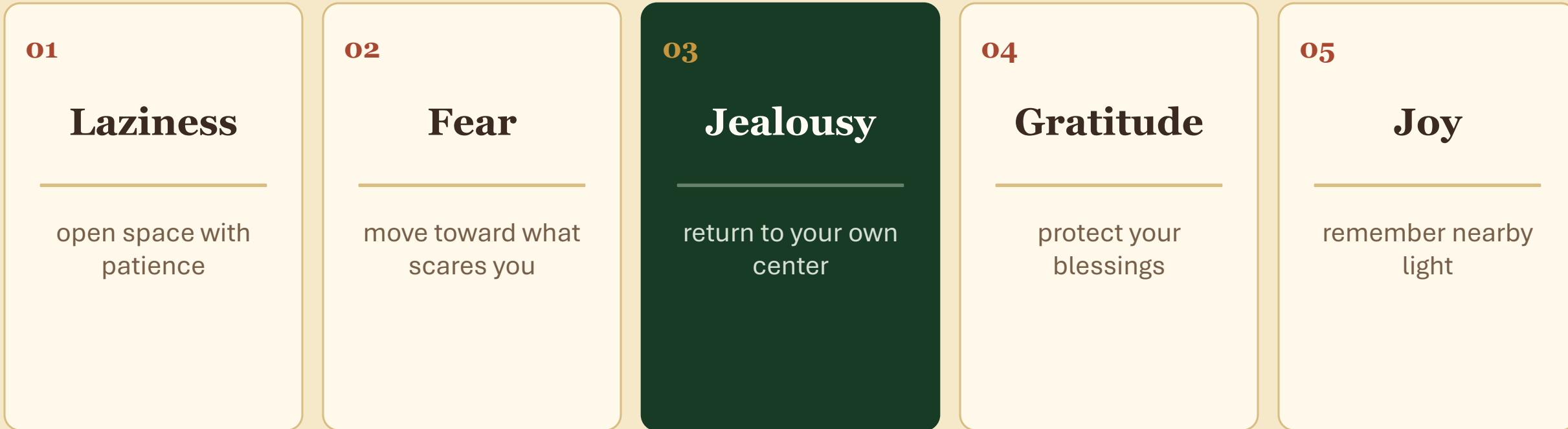
04 **Structured emotional taxonomy**

A fixed list replaces open-ended prompt ambiguity.

Constraint is a feature when trust is the product.

04 Designing

A small taxonomy makes reflection understandable



Five of ten categories shown

The taxonomy is intentionally bounded: enough range to feel personal, small enough to remain testable.

05

User Testing

What changed after real use



05 User Testing

Real use surfaced problems no amount of self-testing could catch

01

Category–verse mismatch

A “jealousy” selection returned an unrelated verse.

02

Verify mistaken for search

Broad words such as “water” were treated as quotation checks.

03

Logo felt too small

A professional designer flagged weak visual hierarchy; fixed same day.

Each finding changed the implementation, copy, or interface, not just an assumption.

05 User Testing

Post-launch feedback made the value tangible

“

*“Blind imitation of them has brought me to ruin:
two hundred curses on that imitation”*

Rumi, Mathnavi, Book 2, Line 0563

Truly, imitating people who live in painful egoic minds has destroyed my sense of self and made me miserable. Many curses upon this blind imitation.

Show me another

Was this helpful?

Yes

No

FIRST REACTION

“This is awesome Delara! ...this can be a great and more responsible way to use AI.”

AFTER RE-READING

“The value: ensuring AI is not hallucinating... Then I can see that this is highly accurate translations.”

– Odette

“I found the translation comprehensive... it captures the meanings very well.”

– reader from a Rumi-interest group

06

Evaluation

Bugs, metrics & early results



06 Evaluation: Self-Testing

Adversarial self-testing caught issues before real users ever saw them

01

Altered-quote false positive

Changing one word (reversing meaning) was still marked “Confirmed.”

02

Half-line non-recognition

A valid partial line returned “not found” despite matching half a real verse.

03

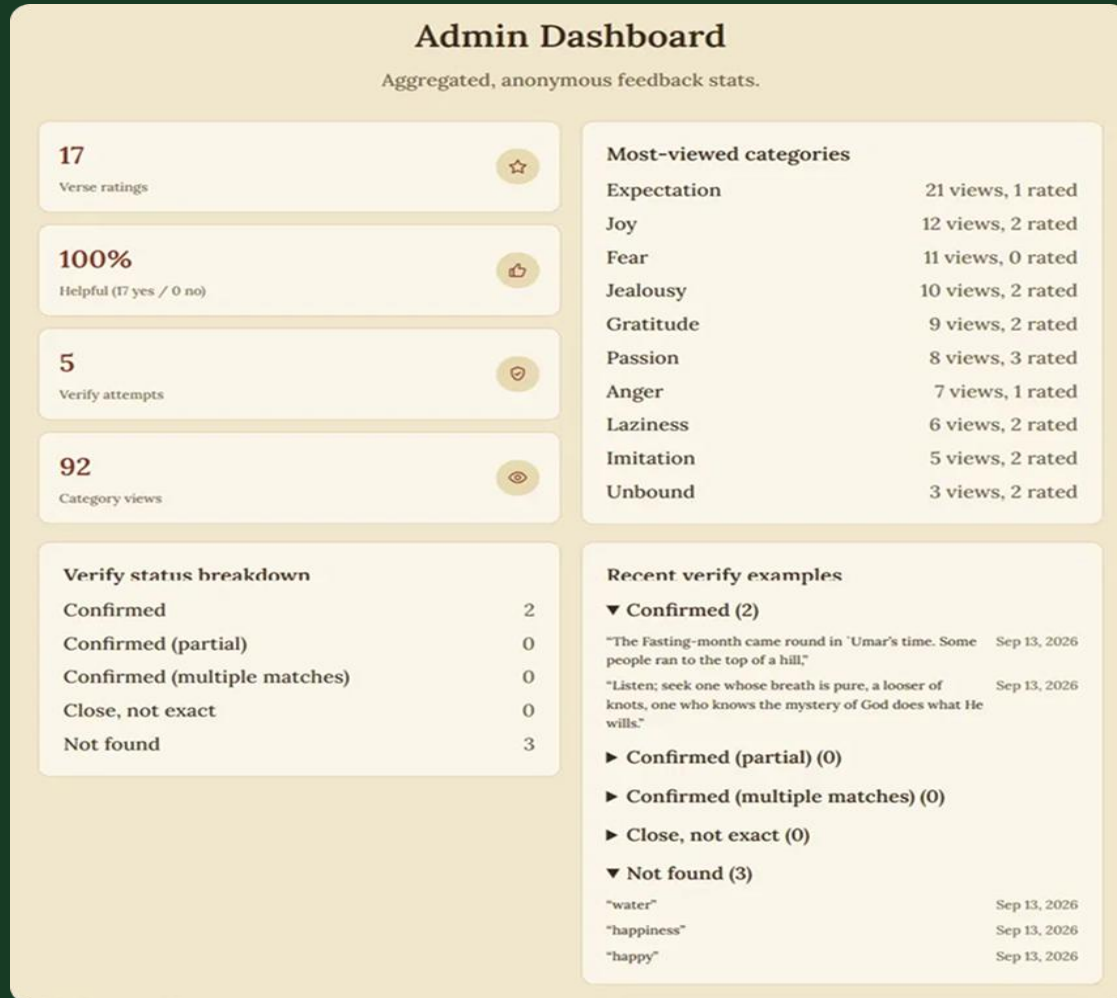
Single-match blindness

A phrase inside multiple verses returned only the first match, not every one.

All three were fixed and re-verified before the product was shared with any real tester.

06 Evaluation

Early signals are positive, yet intentionally modest



92
category views

17
verse ratings

100%
helpful ratings

5
verification attempts

Promising usability signal, not evidence of broad product-market fit.

07

Limitations

Scope, sample size & evaluator bias



07 Limitations

The evidence has clear boundaries

- | | | |
|-------|-------------------------------|--|
| ⚠️ 01 | Small sample | 4 survey respondents and a handful of testers. |
| ⚠️ 02 | Single evaluator | No independent or double-blind review. |
| ⚠️ 03 | Narrow dataset | 30 verses across Books 1–4 only. |
| ⚠️ 04 | Interpretive bias | Deep familiarity may influence what feels correct. |
| ⚠️ 05 | Communication friction | One tester needed a second reading to grasp the value. |
-

Directional learning, not statistical proof.

08

Key Takeaways

Evidence-led learning



08 Key Takeaways

Five learnings generalize beyond this product

- 01  **Explain the ethical value before presenting the interface.**

- 02  **Make source credibility visible at the moment of use.**

- 03  **Use constraints to reduce ambiguous AI behavior.**

- 04  **Treat tester confusion as evidence, not as user error.**

- 05  **Disclose the limits of both the dataset and the evaluation.**

09

Conclusion

What Rumi Mirror demonstrates



09 Conclusion

What Rumi Mirror demonstrates

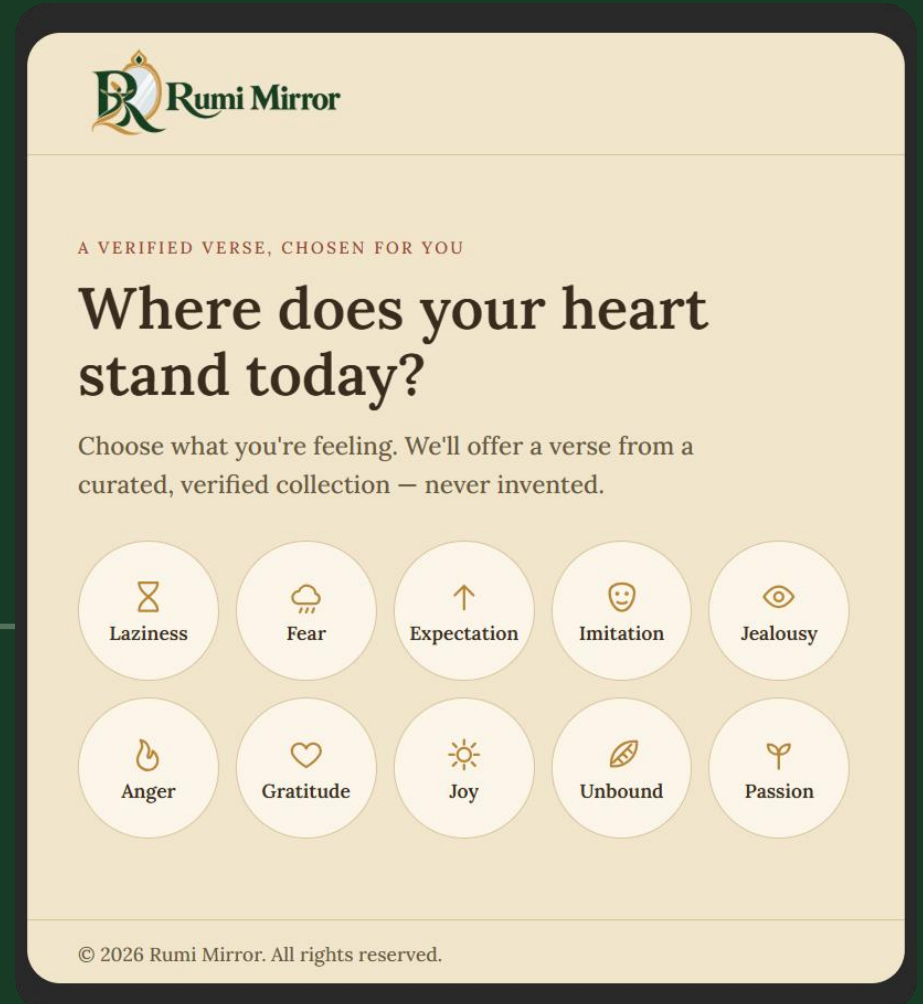
A small product can make a meaningful ethical argument.

By refusing to generate sacred text, showing exact sources, and designing around real trust concerns, Rumi Mirror turns AI restraint into a user benefit.

✓ Focused MVP

30 verses · 10 categories · no accounts

🔗 Live prototype: <https://rumimirror.netlify.app>



10

Generative AI Disclosure

How AI was used



10 Generative AI Disclosure

AI was a tool, not the author of the evidence

<> **Claude (Anthropic), including its coding agent, supported:**

- Technical architecture planning and application code
- Wording and concept refinement
- Report and research-log structure
- Debugging, data display, and verification logic

HUMAN RESPONSIBILITY

Verse selection, citations, interpretations, and authenticity verdicts were reviewed by the designer for accuracy and originality.

11

Sources

Translation & interpretation



11 Sources

Translation, interpretation, and verification

VERSE TRANSLATIONS

Reynold A. Nicholson's public-domain English translation of the Mathnavi, Books 1–4.

INTERPRETATIONS

Persian-language summaries of Mr. Parviz Shahbazi's teachings on the [Ganj-e Hozour](#) program, prepared by the [Ganj-e Hozour Verse Commentary Digest](#), and translated into English by [Delara Mozdbar](#).

VERIFICATION PRINCIPLE

Every displayed verse is paired with a traceable book and line reference.

The product retrieves from a fixed collection. It does not improvise quotations.

Trust is designed into the content model, not added as a disclaimer.

12

Questions & Information

Contact & closing thought



12

QUESTIONS AND INFORMATION



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AI can help protect cultural and literary heritage, not just generate content freely.